SWELL

A surf session tracking app designed for the modern surfer

UX Research · Wireframing · Hi-Fi Prototype

The Problem

Surfers have no dedicated tool to track their sessions

Most surfers rely on memory, notes apps, or paper logs to record wave height, duration, and spot. None of these tools are built around how surfers actually think making it easy to forget sessions, lose progress, and miss patterns in their performance.

User Research

What we learned

- Most surfers forget session details within a few days
- Existing tools like Notes apps and journals feel clunky and disconnected
- Surfers want a quick, frictionless way to log sessions on the go
- Progress tracking is a key motivator for staying committed to the sport

User Research

In their own words

"I forget my sessions within a week - there's nothing to look back on"

- Weekly surfer, San Diego

"I've tried notes apps but they're not built for surfing at all"

- Intermediate surfer, 3+ years

"I just want to see if I'm getting better over time."

- Beginner surfer, Austin Tx

User Personas

Who we designed for

Jake Rivera, 28
Weekly surfer · San Diego, CA

Goals
- Log sessions quickly after a surf
- Track wave height and duration over time
- Look back on progress month to month

Frustrations
- Forgets details within days
- Notes app feels generic and clunky
- No way to visualize his improvement

Maya Chen, 24
Beginner surfer · Austin, TX

Goals
- Build consistency as a new surfer
- Remember which spots worked best for her
- Stay motivated by seeing small wins

Frustrations
- Overwhelmed by complex tracking apps
- Wants something simple and surf-specific
- Hard to remember sessions without a log

Key Features

What makes it work

Quick Logging

Log a session in under 30 seconds — wave height, duration, spot, and notes

Progress Tracking

See trends over time with visual charts and session summaries

Session History

Browse all past sessions with filters for date, spot, and conditions

Spot Memory

Remember which locations work best for you based on past logs

Design Process

Lo-fidelity wireframes

"Early sketches focused on layout, flow, and core functionality"

app name/logo

good morning, jake (maybe wave emoji)

+ Log New Session

recent sessions

Trestles • Feb 20
4ft • 90 min

Mavericks • Feb 18
6ft • 60 min

Pipeline • Feb 15
8ft • 120 min

Home | History | Stats

← Back Log a Session

[Date & Time]

[Location]

[Wave Height]

[Duration]

[Conditions]

[Notes]

[Save Session]

[History] [Filter ▾]

Trestles • Feb 20
4ft • 90 min

Mavericks • Feb 18
6ft • 60 min

Pipeline • Feb 15
8ft • 120 min

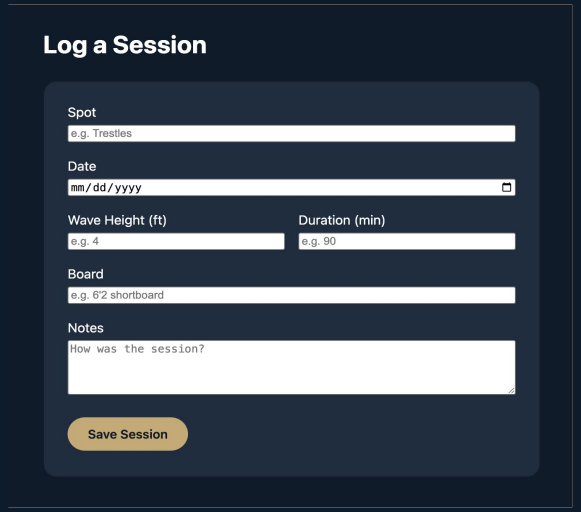
Trestles • Feb 10
3ft • 45 min

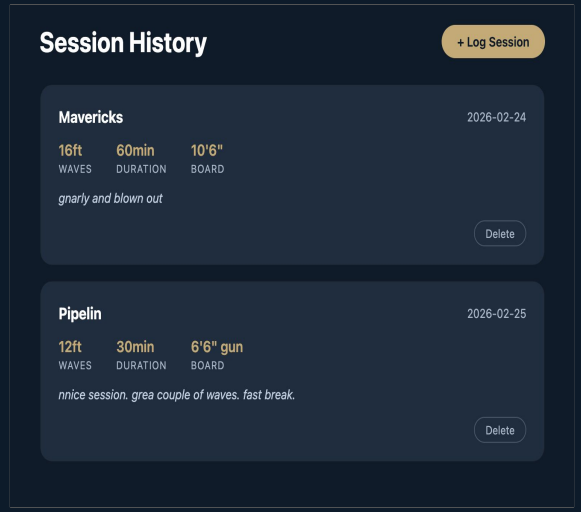
Rincon • Feb 5
5ft • 75 min

Home | History | Stats

Final Implemented UI

Bringing the Swell visual system to a working web app



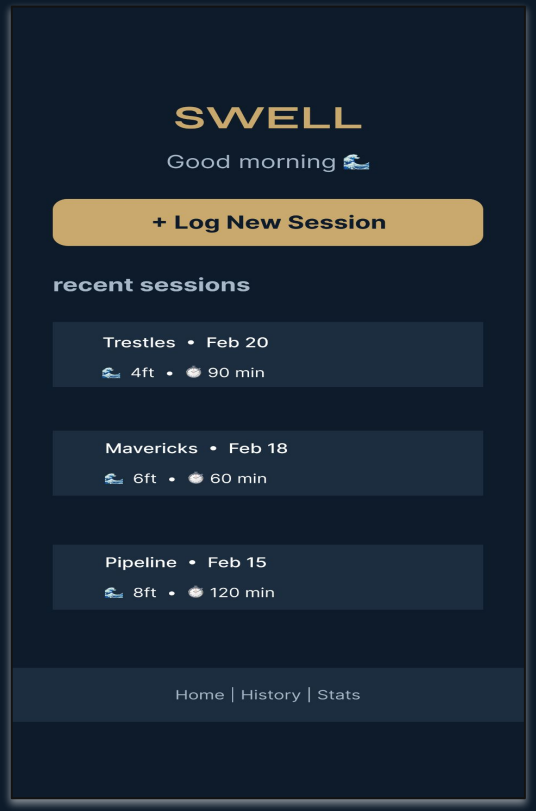


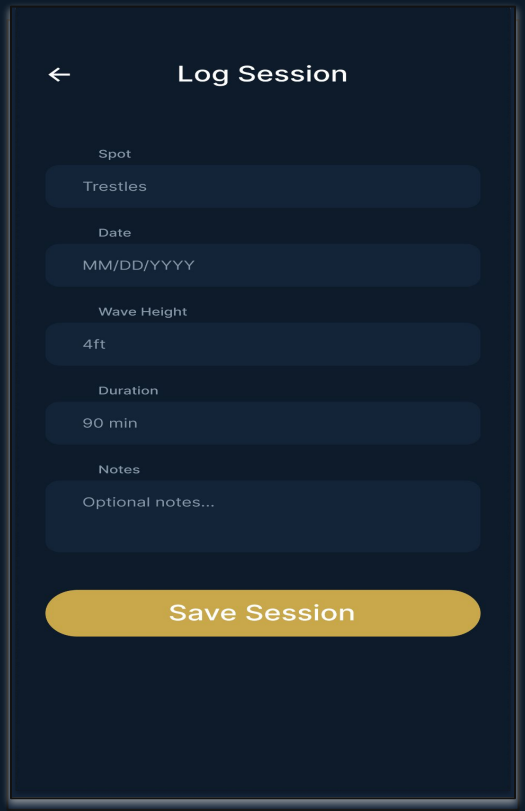
Built with React + Vite, Context API, CSS Modules, and Recharts to closely match the high-fidelity designs and support future evolution into a native app.

Hi-Fi wireframes

High-fidelity mockups

"Refined designs applying the full visual system — typography, color, and components"





Usability Testing

What we learned from testing

- Tested with 8 surfers ranging from beginners to weekly regulars
- Key insight: Speed matters more than features - users want to log in 30 seconds or less
- Simplified the logging flow based on feedback to reduce unnecessary fields
- High satisfaction with visual progress charts - 7/8 users wanted this as a home screen

Impact

Key Takeaways

- Designed a tool specifically for surfers that removes friction from session tracking
- Validated that sports-specific apps serve users better than generic note-taking tools
- Learned the importance of designing for one-handed use in the outdoor, post activity contexts
- Discovered progress visualization is a powerful motivator for habit formation

Next Steps

Where this goes next

- Build a functional prototype to test the full user flow end-to-end
- Add social features - allow users to share sessions with friends or surf crews
- Integrate tide and weather data to provide session recommendations
- Explore partnerships with surf brands and local shops for distribution

Thank You

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Building tools that make life easier